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“Drink the Past Dry” by Ghostlight Ensemble puts a science fiction twist on the otherwise familiar setting of a Chicago bar.
Nonfiction films: Anthony Kaufman on why they are imperiled — and why they’ll survive.



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Economic uncertainties pose a risk to the housing market in the south suburbs.
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Chicago Tribune



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SUNDAY, APRIL 27, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



‘YOUR JOURNEY IS YOUR REWARD, BABY’

Few squeezed more out of their days than the larger-than-life Bears great

By Dan Wiederer | Chicago Tribune

The voicemail was left with an odd combination of reluctance and concern.

Mongo, give a shout when you get a chance. Just wanted to check in.

Whispers had been circulating that Chicago Bears great Steve McMichael was coming apart physically and struggling to understand why.

What exactly was going on? Was there reason for worry? Any validity to fears that McMichael suddenly was face to face with a bleak diagnosis?

This was in February 2021, during a spike in the COVID-19 pandemic. Thus McMichael’s uncharacteristic absence from public view had gone mostly undetected.

For some in his inner circle, though, McMichael’s disappearance triggered uneasiness. He had been telling his closest friends more frequently about the problems he was having with his neck, his shoulders, his arms. Even when opportunities for autograph signings or on-air analyst roles were available, he declined or stepped away.

By that point, McMichael had been told by multiple doctors and specialists that he was

Above: Former Bears player Steve McMichael on April 22, 2021, at his Romeoville home. McMichael had been recently diagnosed with ALS. **BRIAN CASSELLA/ TRIBUNE**

almost certainly staring down the barrel of ALS. Amyotrophic lateral sclerosis. Lou Gehrig’s disease.

That was why his arms were tingling, doctors at the Mayo Clinic, Rush University Medical Center and UIC Medical Center explained. That was why his shoulders had been aching so badly. Why, at 63, his strength was diminishing much faster than it should have been.

That — and not a lingering neck issue related to his football and pro wrestling days — was why he was struggling to twist the caps off Coke

Turn to McMichael, Page 4

Trump voters reflect on 2nd term

Gauging supporters’ opinions of president’s first 100 days in office

By Angie Leventis Lourgos
Chicago Tribune

After more than four decades working in the paper industry, Gaetano “Guy” Spinelli poured his life savings into developing an eco-friendly yet durable paper straw and opened his company, Boss Straw, in Woodstock in 2021.

Then in February, President Donald Trump signed an executive order promoting plastic straws while declaring that paper straws “don’t work.”

“I’ve had them many times. On occasion they break. They explode,” Trump said. “If something’s hot, they don’t last very long, like a matter of minutes, sometimes a matter of seconds. It’s a ridiculous situation.”

The president’s rant incensed Spinelli, who had voted for Trump in November. Business immediately dropped following the executive order.

“He’s put me from a profitable picture to a non-profitable company,” Spinelli said. “And my

Turn to Trump, Page 6

INSIDE

Trump airs doubts on Putin’s aims

The president on Saturday said Russia’s series of strikes “makes me think that maybe he doesn’t want to stop the war.” **Nation & World**

The Bears’ ‘match made in heaven’

How the Bears settled on “Idaho tough” tight end Colston Loveland at No. 10. He’s “exactly what we’re looking for.” **Chicago Sports**

Geographic balance in Senate seats may end

With Durbin retiring, upstate-downstate tradition appears at risk

By Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

Ever since Illinois voters gained the right to directly elect their U.S. senators in 1913, they have largely embraced — whether by choice or chance — an unofficial tradition of splitting the state’s two Senate seats geographically with one coming from the Chicago area and the other from downstate, regardless of party.

For the past 28 years, it has been Democratic Sen. Dick Durbin

of Springfield who has served as the downstate senator alongside a string of Chicago-area counterparts: Democrat Carol Moseley Braun of Chicago, Republican Sen. Peter Fitzgerald of Inverness, Democratic senator and future President Barack Obama of Chicago, appointed Democratic Sen. Roland Burris of Chicago, Republican Sen. Mark Kirk of Highland Park and current Democratic Sen. Tammy Duckworth of northwest suburban Hoffman Estates.

But with Durbin’s announcement Wednesday that he will retire following the 2026 election, the

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FRANCISCO SECO/AP

Final farewell to ‘People’s Pope’

The coffin of Pope Francis arrives at St. Mary Major Basilica in Rome on Saturday. World leaders and rank-and-file Catholic faithful bade farewell to Francis in a funeral that highlighted his concern for people on the peripheries and reflected his wish to be remembered as a simple pastor.

About 250,000 flocked to the funeral Mass at the Vatican. **Nation & World**

Go to our eNewspaper for a 4-page section on Pope Francis’ funeral. Scan the code at right.



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177th year No. 117 © Chicago Tribune

TODAY’S WEATHER High **68** Low **53**
Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 20